



Exhuming the Dead and Talking to the Living: The 1914 Fire at the Florida Industrial School for Boys—Invoking the Uncanny as a Site of Analysis

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SUMMARY *This article revisits the 1914 fire at the Florida Industrial School for Boys in Marianna, Florida. It resulted in the deaths of ten people and led to increased levels of public focus on the school's mission, purpose, and its day-to-day operational practices. Those who burned in the fire were buried on campus in the area known as "Boot Hill Cemetery." Very little documentation about the history of the cemetery, or who is buried there, exists; and the exact locations of individual burials were never documented. In 2013, a University of South Florida (USF) research team began excavation of the burials located in the area of Boot Hill. Their efforts have been justified by requests from family members to learn about missing loved ones. Exhuming bodies of those who perished in the fire, as well as those who died at other times, demands that we think critically about what is recovered, what is invoked, and what is next and for whom. I introduce Freud's concept of "the uncanny" as a frame of reference for talking about things that surface when one recovers human remains or in some way revisits the site of a past, perhaps long-hidden, traumatic event. [exhumations, Florida, memorialization, memory, reform schools, segregation, uncanny]*

The whole bitter story of the fire at Marianna is one of either gross negligence or worse, and the state of Florida is going to inquire into all circumstances of the accident, which was little short of a crime, and it is going to fix the blame and punish the ones found guilty. Eight fine boys, the wards of the state, sent to a state institution by the owner of the law for their reformation, were burned to death and the lives of more than a hundred others were placed in extreme peril. Why? (Excerpt from an editorial entitled "Let us Have the Facts," published in the Miami Herald Historical Archive [MHHA], November 20, 1914a)

The 1914 fire at the Florida Industrial School for Boys in Marianna, Florida was a tragic and unthinkable event. It resulted in the deaths of ten people—eight boys and two adults—and led to increased levels of public focus on the school's mission, purpose, and day-to-day operational practices. There were also calls to find out the facts and "fix the responsibility" (MHHA 1914b) published by Florida newspapers such as the *Miami Herald* and *Tampa Times*. Those who burned in the fire were later buried on campus in the area known as "Boot Hill Cemetery."

The state of Florida opened its first juvenile center as the Florida State Reform School on January 1, 1900. It was established by law as a completely segregated institution with white students separated from "colored" students



Figure 1.
Boot Hill Cemetery. Marianna, Florida. February 2012. Photo courtesy of
author. [Color figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

until the late 1960s. The school remained in operation, under various names, until it was closed on June 30, 2011 under the name Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys. The area designated as “Boot Hill Cemetery” was established on school property in the early days of the school and is located on the north side of the school, the side designated as the “colored” side. It was positioned in a small, elevated clearing immediately adjacent to the school’s garbage dump (Kimmerle et al. 2012). According to a Florida Department of Law Enforcement (FDLE) report:

In the early years, the facility was located on almost 1400 acres and periodically housed male and female students who were as young as six years old. Many of these students were committed to the facility for minor offenses, such as “incurability” or “truancy.” “White” and “Colored” students were segregated from one another until 1968. The School had two campuses— the South Side or “Number 1” side for the white students, and the North Side or “Number 2” side for colored students. The School’s North Side campus, where the cemetery was located, was permanently closed between 1990 and 1991. (FDLE Investigative report for case no. EI-04-0005, 2010:3)

Today thirty-one white metal crosses mark the site of the cemetery (Fig. 1). However, these markers do not correspond to the actual interments, as burials were not originally marked. Very little documentation about the history of the cemetery or who is buried there exists. The exact locations of individual burials were never documented. Recorded burials in this location

occurred from 1914 to 1952. But, even at the time that recorded deaths occurred, multiple investigations and reports summarized different accounts of who died and the surrounding circumstances (see Kimmerle et al. 2012).

In 2013, a University of South Florida (USF) research team began excavation of the burials located in the area of Boot Hill with the support and permission of the Florida Cabinet.¹ Efforts by the USF team to exhume graves at Boot Hill Cemetery and to identify the dead have been justified by requests from family members to learn about missing loved ones and by the state as an act of accountability (Kimmerle et al. 2012). Through the course of the initial investigation—using ground-penetrating radar (GPR) and other archaeological field methods in combination with archival research and interviews of former employees, inmates, and families—the USF research team estimated that there were nearly 100 deaths and fifty burials located in the area of Boot Hill. These findings are in contrast to the thirty-one crosses erected on the grounds in the 1990s as part of an effort to mark and recognize the burial ground. To date, the USF research team has found a total of fifty-one individuals buried in fifty-five graves, of which three were victims of the 1914 fire.²

November 18, 2014 marked the hundredth-year anniversary of the fire. A conference, entitled “Research & Remembrance: 100 Years after the Fatal Fire at Dozier,” was held at the University of South Florida to draw attention to the fire and to the current research being done by the USF team. The day-long conference, which was open to the public, included a wide range of people, such as men who had been sent to Dozier as boys, families of boys who were buried in Boot Hill Cemetery who had recently been identified,³ historians, anthropologists, journalists, clergy, lawyers, and other law enforcement personnel. In the evening there was a program entitled “Recognition of Families & Commemoration” for the 1914 fire victims, sponsored by the Florida Council of Churches and the NAACP. The conference keynote speaker was Michael Blakey.⁴ Discussions spanned a range of topics, from civil rights and juvenile justice to collecting DNA for human identification, to reparations and memorializing. Participating in the symposium allowed me to reflect in intimate and critical ways on my role as a scholar and member of the USF research team working to learn more about boys buried at Boot Hill Cemetery. For example, I am linked to this project—and to this discussion of burials, exhumations, and quest for memorializing of the dead some 100 years later—because my relationship to the past is through engagement with the living. This relationship is now an integral part of the entire process.

Exhuming bodies of those who perished in the fire, as well as those who died under other circumstances at other times in the school’s history, demands that we think critically about this work, for example, what is recovered and what is invoked; what comes next (i.e., what should be memorialized and how justice should be pursued); and for whom should it be done (i.e., who or what should be the subject of our attention and focus—the dead; families of the dead; institutions; failed policies; future generations?). In this discussion, I open a space for thinking about the “uncanny”—the 1914 fire and the subsequent burial and recovery of these

bodies and others at the Boot Hill Cemetery—as a dynamic link between the past and the present. Recognized as a historic cemetery, Boot Hill is protected under Florida Statutes (Chapters 267 and 704.08), which mandate historical resources and the rights of families to have access. This makes it a potentially valuable cultural resource for documenting community heritage and understanding past events. I introduce Freud's concept of "the uncanny" as a frame of reference for talking about things that surface (i.e., memories, stories, feelings, and other details about the past) when one recovers human remains or, in some way, revisits the site of a past, perhaps long hidden, traumatic event. The appearance of the uncanny is, by definition, the appearance of that which is thought to be hidden (or buried) and would remain so but has been brought to the surface (see Freud 2003[1919]). Employing the framework of the uncanny in the context of the exhumation process shifts it, from possibly being a benign or rote process of recovery to a series of nuanced activities/actions and complex emotions involving the living.

For example, throughout this project, the needs and feelings of the living had to be constantly negotiated. Processes of excavation and exhumation at the Boot Hill burial site were technically precise and a painstakingly labor intensive endeavor. Ground-penetrating radar (GPR) and other equipment was used. Human labor was expended to clear brush, remove impediments, dig trenches, and locate bodies. Scientific methods (archaeological, bioarchaeological, forensic) were applied for recovering, counting, and documenting individual items or fragments found in or near graves, such as teeth, bone, coffin handles, and nails. However, what also had to be addressed were the complexity of feelings, fears, meanings, and memories of living people, families, and communities engaged in confronting their relationship to the past with each recovered body. Their lives and experiences were an integral part of the process and could not be ignored. Sometimes there were feelings of anger and frustration. At other times there were feelings of relief and gratitude, shared in the form of overwhelming displays of happiness, joy, tears, and hugs (by those in proximity to, or impacted by, the exhumation process and subsequent finding).

Invoking the Uncanny

There are multiple ways of thinking about the recovery of bodies and the identification of remains. For example, these ways include scientific processes of inquiry, dialog, conversations, questions, and active engagement with families and communities—all of which complicate notions of closure, justice, and the process of memorializing. Together such ways of thinking recognize and attend to the dynamic, unstructured, and disruptive aspects of the process of exhuming, recovering, and identifying bodies at the Boot Hill burial ground project. It is in trying to reach an understanding of the range of things associated with this process that the uncanny can be invoked as a site of analysis/site of knowledge. This is because the uncanny is focused on (or, provides a framework for) how people experience what happens when confronted with the past.

Specifically, I posit that healing is a process; mourning is active not static (and it is moved into and out of without a clear end point or destination); and closure is part of a dynamic continuum of activity that reflects an ongoing engagement with the uncanny (between people experiencing a trauma and that which evokes the experience). This is because the uncanny can occur (and often does occur) in familiar and comfortable settings. Nevertheless, the uncanny links these settings to the unfamiliar and to secret/hidden spaces, which trigger unscripted responses that cannot be easily closed temporarily or with finality. The notion of the uncanny—with respect to events that are experienced as traumatic, deeply troubling on a visceral level, life changing, and in many cases associated with death or proximity to death—is part of a framework for exploring the past dynamically. This is an important consideration because there are associated tensions surrounding (1) understanding exhumation of the dead as a long-awaited healing of an old wound (i.e., a body found/named/identified and reburied equals closure of an open wound publically and privately); (2) the recovery of memory; and (3) the pursuit of justice and acts of memorializing (see Sime 2016). In an article entitled, “Exhumations: The Search for the Dead and the Resurgence of the Uncanny in Contemporary Spain,” Jennifer Sime seeks to “move beyond therapeutic discourse to open up a critical space for examining the place of the dead in contemporary Spain” (2013:36). Sime’s approach serves as a catalyst for this discussion. In utilizing the uncanny as a means for understanding memories that surface at unscripted and unanticipated moments as a result of the exhumation or discovery of human remains (i.e., bones, teeth, organs), a critical space for examining the place of the living in discussions of the past is opened. This is important in the context to exhumations, where forensic and bioarchaeological science/methods typically organize the sequence and direction of steps in terms of discovery, recovery, analysis and identification, preservation and documentation, and decisions about closure with respect to material cultural remains. However, there are other considerations. Additionally, tools for critically addressing intangible aspects of the process, including impact and implications for the living, are also increasingly sought.

The rediscovery of the African Burial Ground in New York City in 1991—a historic unmarked cemetery in which the remains of 419 graves were excavated after human remains were uncovered during the construction of a federal office building in lower Manhattan—is instructive. In this case, those uncovered remains were later found to be a fraction of an estimated 20,000 burials associated with the largest colonial-era burial ground for people of African descent. Subsequent community responses⁵ and engagement in the exhumation, identification, and reburial process were intense. It culminated in the designation of the site as a “national monument” and federal memorial by the National Park Service (Davis and Mullins 2013; Mack and Blakey 2004; Nelson 1918). For the African Burial Ground, methodological tools for responding to what was uncovered and to what needed to occur next were comprehensive, including material, spiritual, civic, social, emotional, and ethical considerations. For example, there were public forums for dealing with



Figure 2.

Fire at the School for Boys in Marianna, Florida. 195-?. Courtesy of State Archives of Florida, *Florida Memory*, <http://floridamemory.com/items/show/258296>. [Image number: DSB0030]

the remains, community committees, the mayor's taskforce, the Committee of Descendants, the Friends of the African Burial Ground committee, and an advisory council. There were also spiritual rituals and public events honoring the dead at the site. The stakeholder groups and the various activities of healing and honoring were an intimate and integral part of the exhumation process (see Davis and Mullins 2013).

What is Recovered?

As with the rediscovery of the African Burial Ground, the 1914 fire at the Florida Industrial School for Boys and the exhumation of bodies associated with it also brings to the surface (1) systemic processes and implications of unchecked institutional power on marginalized groups or those considered throwaway in light of larger aims and ambitions; (2) forms and methods of racial segregation and processes of isolation and control, as seen through the lens of spatial and social geography articulated in black and white; and (3) issues of memorialization and social justice as critical aspects of community engagement, advocacy, identity, representation, public memory, and heritage preservation. The process of determining what is buried and what is recovered consists of engaging/interrogating archives, which are often underutilized sites of knowledge about the past, as well as incorporating underrepresented narratives into public dialog as an active act of

intervention. It is my aim here to encourage and to impart a broader range of participation in critical discussions about unchecked institutional power and about the power to access and control resources and processes impacting basic life-sustaining needs in ways that target and disadvantage a specific group or groups.

The Fire and Implications of Unchecked Institutional Power on Marginalized Groups

Fires beyond the 1914 event were a common occurrence at the Florida State Reform School for Boys in Marianna (Fig. 2). However, none of the subsequent fires reported accounted for a loss of life under such horrific circumstances as was reported in that case. The 1914 fire resulted in the deaths of ten people out of an estimated 100 people thought to be in the building at the time it started, although, there are varying accounts of the exact number of boys who died. Findings of the USF Research team submitted in a report to the Florida Cabinet and governor stress the impact and implications of systematic processes (i.e., power embedded in the day-to-day operations of an institution or program that continually reproduces the means of empowering or advantaging one group while simultaneously disadvantaging another). Also noted was the application of unchecked institutional power applied by those in authority over the lives of marginalized groups—to boys sent to the reform school who were typically poor, black, and socially, historically, and legally vulnerable to the history and practice of slavery and segregation in the United States. This application of power was coupled with demands from businesses for inexpensive labor. Specifically, the report states that:

We also know from the historical documents that until the 1930s, often when families could not afford to send money for bus fare home, children were paroled for labor to local plantations/farms and businesses until they could afford their own transportation. Parole for labor lasted for years in some cases. It was at times a practice of indentured servitude. At least three of the boys who died were paroled for labor and brought back to the school for burial. These systematic practices of marginalization are further reflected in record keeping that lacked consistent standards, proper enforcement, and oversight because of unchecked institutional power and policies that considered certain lives as *throwaway* (Kimmerle et al. 2016:128).

The work of the USF Research team and this discussion makes visible the lives of boys who some considered “throwaway” at the hands of those who sought and secured financial and economic gain (or “larger” aims) from the maintenance of a system, and specifically an institution (the Florida State Reform School for Boys known today as the Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys), that failed to properly care for the boys it was responsible to protect. These practices have had, and continue to have, serious implications.

Newspapers throughout Florida and across the country published accounts of the 1914 fire. The reporting of the journalists who produced these accounts clearly identified and named marginalized victims of the fire

and other school atrocities, as well as those who were responsible for the safety of boys at the school and their lack of responsiveness and accountability. For example, the *Miami Herald* reported on the lack of responsibility exhibited by the state of Florida for the safety, care, and well-being of boys in its custody. They cited such things as: insufficient fire protection, neglect by those in charge, the transfer of campus officials considered responsible for oversight to another school, as well as unsafe forms of punishment that included locking boys in rooms with barred windows (MHHA 1914b,c). Another *Miami Herald* article reported on conditions at the school based on findings issued by a United States Public Health Service visit. The article, written four years after the fire, drew attention to things such as fleas, lack of sanitary rules, multiple cases of pneumonia, lack of proper nourishment, dirty mattresses, lack of towels, and limited access to bathing (MHHA 1918). The same article went on to state, "In the face of that report, every tortured, lice-bitten, naked body tossing in filth on a mattress harder than the cement floor it rested on, cries out for mercy, for death, even, to release it from its horrible torture" (MHHA 1918).

The USF Research team conducted formal interviews that have been audio recorded and informal interviews with men who attended the schools as boys, family members of people who attended Dozier, and others associated with the school or with knowledge of the school, including leaders in civic organizations such as the NAACP, members of faith organizations, politicians, former staff, representatives of the media, and citizens of the local community (Kimmerle et al. 2016). Specifically, from 2012 to 2015, as a member of the USF team I interviewed men who were boys at Dozier. I learned a great deal about the school's history from these interviews. Some of the men interviewed indicated that fire and other tragic deaths/events were a regular part of their memory of the school. Some surmised that the school's eventual closure was a result of a history of neglect and lack of attention to things well known to authorities and that resulted in abuse, trauma, and pain for many boys but were allowed to continue, such as the severe beatings and punishment that took place at a building called the White House on the Dozier campus (FDLE 2010). The following excerpts are from an interview I conducted with one of about fifteen men with whom I spoke. They all had been sent to Dozier as boys.⁶ On November 8, 2012, I interviewed Wally Jones^{*7} in Lakeland, Florida. He was sent to Dozier as a nine-year-old boy in 1952. Jones' insight into Dozier during the 1950s and 1960s paints a graphic portrait of his life as an African American boy on a segregated campus. He witnessed several funerals and experienced the grading and punishment system that was an integral part of life for boys at the school. His descriptions, taken directly from the interview transcription, are representative of stories and experiences shared by many of the other men who were sent to Dozier between 1950 and 1970 (see Fig. 3). He shared the following,

He was just—he was just—yeah, he was just one of many, though. I can't recall the names of all of them, but that graveyard was full. Really. Long before I got there in 1952, They had a grave [sic] there from forties. Mrs. Boleyn had a fire there or something, and fifteen or twenty boys got burned up. In the late forties,



Figure 3.

African American boys with pastor during a possible memorial or funeral service at the School for Boys in Marianna, Florida. 195-. Courtesy of State Archives of Florida, Florida Memory, <https://www.floridamemory.com/items/show/258423>. [Image number: DSB0093]

'48, '49. We—we just heard—it was this—some of the stories that was goin' around from one of the boys, when he got there. I'm trying to think of my principals' name in the school. His name was Crawford. The principal—our principal in the school, I think his name was Crawford. I can't recall [sic]—I could find them today, if someone took me on the grounds. They had a area where they raised pigs, and near that area, they had a hill where they kept some of the pigs fenced in; had a little hill out there. I remember one of the first funeral [sic] I attended out there...—his name was Billy Jackson. He had ran [sic] away, they caught him, and a couple days, some of the boys had asked about where he was—nobody would say anything, and then, but all of a sudden, we had about a—several days later, we had to attend a funeral on this little hill. And I remember looking down in the hole, wasn't all that well, because—I mean, remember I was very young then. I never understood what happened to 'em. He was vibrant, he was all right, he's—nobody ever said what happened to him. But that was just one of many.

... Over the course of the years in the time I was there, from nine to sixteen, I worked in various [capacities?] there. There were real—they had a grading system. They referred to it as an Ace, a Pilot, a Pioneer, an Explorer, and a Grub. And when you was at the lowest level, and you had an infraction, they'd beat you. They beat you horribly. They beat you good. A leather strap about a foot-and-a-half long with tacks in it, and you couldn't sit down for two or three days. You (inaudible), you go over lie down and they—they—they—very bad, and I've seen people there, little more that was there than me, that just disappeared, and when you ran away, and they really—they really beat you, they really beat you.

They had a—two employees taking turns beatin' you. Mr. Mitchell and Mr. Mobley. Mr. Mobley was from Tampa, and Mr. Mitchell, I don't know where he's been from. I went to school there, I—looking back at it now, I don't—It wasn't a nice place to be for a young man—young boy. They have a graveyard there, and they have a lot of unmarked graves there. Boys just disappeared. I—I've seen a article in the paper some time ago, they happened to mentioned something about that. No one ever talked to me, but, boys just disappeared and when we asked about, "Where he at—going?" Nobody would—and we was young [sic], we never questioned the authorities, at that time. Well, I wish I would've thought. (Wally Jones,* born 1942, attended Dozier 1952–1968. Interview with author on November 8, 2012).

My interviews with these men—who had all been sent to Dozier as boys—coupled with the USF research report of findings (Kimmerle et al. 2016), newspaper articles, and other collected information together highlight legal, social, and cultural experiences of people whose lives mark a period of the school's history through the 1960s and also America's history of transition from legalized segregation to integration and civil rights. This was a time in which the legal system of the United States, and its apparatus of segregation, mandated marginalization, exclusion, and the denial of basic rights, citizenship, justice, freedom of movement, and accountability to a large part of the population of the state of Florida (including the boys at the Florida Industrial School for Boys, as well as their families). These legally mandated practices of marginalization, along with the denial of basic rights of citizenship and expectations of safety, applied to anyone identified as nonwhite but most notably to African Americans. As well, it included children, the poor, homeless, the disabled, and others in need of social services. Such practices of neglect, abuse, and second-class treatment are discernable and highlighted, in part, in the records of the school that have survived into the present. The pattern indicates a lack of consistent standards, proper supervision, oversight, and enforcement, all justified and rationalized on the premise that certain lives lacked value—that is, they were considered "throwaways" (for further details, see Kimmerle et al. 2016).

Segregated Spaces

Forms and methods of racial segregation and processes of isolation and control were articulated in racial terms of black and white at Dozier. This can be readily seen in the social and spatial geography of the campus. A critical review of administrative documents, ledgers, school newspapers, maps, and interview data show the large extent to which race impacted all aspects of life at the school and throughout the state of Florida. For example, school ledgers documented records of students admitted to the school. Although incomplete and sometimes inconsistent with other administrative records kept, these ledgers and ledger entries included information such as the student's name, age, date of birth, parents' names, race, home address, and county; and the name of the presiding judge, the reason for admittance, and a host of other such details. The ledgers, particularly in years prior to 1964, also reflected a system of recordkeeping in which the identification

and written separation of students/inmates based on race was practiced even in administrative documentation. It was a system of recordkeeping in which white boys were listed as separate entries in separate sections within the book from black/“colored” boys. These school ledgers are on file at the Florida State Archives, beginning with entries from Volume 1 in 1915 (Florida School for Boys Student Ledgers 1915-2011).

From a historical perspective, laws enacted by a legislature in Florida controlled by members of the then Democratic party, as was true elsewhere throughout the South, resulted in complete oppression of blacks under restrictive laws known as “Jim Crow” by 1895. These laws mandated segregation at every level of society, and they remained in force until the passing of the Civil Rights Act in 1964 (see Litwack 1998; Wilkerson 1984; Williamson 2013; Woodward 2010, 1951). It would be impossible to understand the Florida State Reform School over the course of its history without critical consideration of the context and impact of the history of slavery and segregation in the United States, particularly those laws, policies, ordinances, and practices relating to criminal justice. Kevin Boyle, in his book, *Arc of Justice*, wrote:

Florida was one of the first southern states to require blacks to ride in separate railroad cars. And the legislature made it a crime to teach black children and white children in the same classroom. As the Democrats made it more and more difficult to be black, whites became more and more determined to assert the power of their race. So they piled prohibition on prohibition. Blacks couldn’t be buried in the same cemeteries as whites. They couldn’t eat in the same restaurants. They couldn’t ride in the front of streetcars. They couldn’t drink from the same drinking fountains. Whites also segregated their workplaces. Blacks could be servants and farm laborers, of course, and they could work in the turpentine and lumber camps, where most whites didn’t want to go. But whites claimed the vast majority of jobs for themselves (2004:56).

By the end of the nineteenth century, Florida relied heavily on the “convict lease system” to house and maintain individuals convicted of crimes. This system placed men and women together in labor camps (Alexander 2012; Boyle 2004; Mancini 2004). Many of the laws created at that time, such as the vagrancy laws, were aimed at increasing the number of convicts, which translated into laborers available for filling these camps. Mathew J. Mancini writes: “There can be little doubt that part of the growth can be attributed to the assiduous enterprise of the labor agents whom Dutton hired to pay the fines of vagrants and transport them to the stockades” (1996:189). He continues to point out that nearly ninety percent of those for whom labor agents paid vagrancy fines in exchange for release to labor camps, were African American (1996:189). Specific to Dozier’s inception as the Florida State Reform School, the original law was issued in 1897 (under the Laws of Florida Ch. 4565, sec. 4, p.108). It stated that two buildings should be built for the segregation of white students from “colored” students. It went on to dictate that the day-to-day operations of the school should maintain complete segregation, including all living, dining, religious, work, and educational activities. This policy continued until the late 1960s (Kimmerle et al. 2016; Lundrigan 1998).

On December 12, 2012, I interviewed Winston Peters,* in Syracuse, New York. He was anxious to tell his story, but he was visibly shaking during

the entire interview. Winston was born in South Carolina in 1945, but he grew up in St. Augustine, Florida. He described his family as dysfunctional and poor, and said he had to fend for himself. The first time he was mandated to Dozier was in 1957. He said that the boys were called students or inmates and that it meant the same thing. When he was there he said the school was called Florida School for Boys in Marianna. The second time he was sent to Marianna he did not know why. He indicated that the judge in his case said he did not do well in school. However, the first time he was sent to the school he said he did wrong, acknowledging that he understood why he was sent. He knew he had done something wrong. When asked about segregation, he provided a description of the segregated campus and his life as an African American boy living on the “colored” side of a school that was divided into two campuses. According to Peters, the school was completely organized by race:

They had a cafeteria on the white side and they had one on the black. We never ate together; we didn't eat with the whites. Excuse me. And—and—you know, we didn't even—we did nothing with the whites. Except for—on one—we—we would go on the white side and we played—like, we had basketball tournaments, you know, against the other cottages. You know, things like that. Because that's where the gym was at, okay? Other than that, we did nothing with the whites. (Interview with author on December 12, 2012)

Additionally, I interviewed Ernest Thompson,* who was born in 1949 and attended Dozier between 1964 and 1965. He was fifteen years old when he and his two brothers were sent to the school. “It was school,” he said, “where education was not a priority.” As an eighth grader, Ernest recounts that he was placed in a third grade class. He would just sit in the class on days he was not assigned to work with the farm crew. When asked about experiences of segregation, he shared this about churches on campus: “Yeah, a black church and a white church. ‘Cause, see, at the time, we weren't integrated, at the time. It really—rarely, we seen the white boys. Rarely, rarely” (Interview with author on September 3, 2013).

Examining segregated spaces and processes of isolation and control—as seen through the lens of spatial and social geography; administrative records and recordkeeping; laws; and historical and ethnographic accounts of the daily life boys at Dozier expressed in terms of race—exposes multiple ways of knowing place. Narratives included here as part of this analysis speak to what else, or what other things, are recovered and invoked at the instance of retrieval and identification of human remains buried during the historical period of segregation in the United States. They also help show in more direct ways how people experienced their daily lives when segregation was the law even at the level of education and reform, such as at Dozier.

What Next and for Whom? Memorialization and Social Justice

The methodological intervention employed by me in this project is what I would term “forensic ethnography.” I am concerned with “what next, and for whom?” that is, what is the best way to proceed properly, ethically, and

humanely with the exhumation and identification of bodies and the myriad of activities, actions, associations, and emotions that are all part of the process. The process is not simply a matter of the material methods to achieve academic and historical results. Rather, the process involves the pursuit of addressing the social, political, emotional, and cultural issues that are the concerns of various audiences, living and dead, in the past, present, and future. Forensic ethnography, as I conceive it, is about adding an element of humanistic concerns and perspectives to our understanding and interpretation of human events particularly associated with death. In the case of Dozier, this pursuit has been brought into the conversation by integrating newspaper and archival accounts of the past with interviews of people in the present regarding their past associations and memories of Dozier and its meaning today. As well, there has been a conscious and active attempt to provide meaningful context to the process through participation (mine and of many others) in community activities and acts of celebration, remembering, and honoring of those no longer present to speak for themselves (i.e., by attending funerals, family reunions, and memorial events). In other words, forensic ethnography is the application of cultural anthropology tools and methods in concert with forensic science, and archaeology/bioarchaeology tools and practices, in order to connect the past to the present in ways that take into account disparities in power along a range of social, cultural, racial, gendered, and economic dimensions.

Asking questions such as “what next and for whom?” includes acknowledging and invoking the uncanny as part of a critical and active act of intervention and advocacy for informing public memory. As previously mentioned, a formal remembrance of the 1914 fire was held at the University of South Florida 100 years later on November 18, 2014. It was a part of a conference entitled “Research & Remembrance: 100 Years after the Fatal Fire at Dozier.” I revisit the implications here because at the conclusion of the event, I asked some of the participants to take part in follow-up interviews. Fifteen of the conference organizers and presenters took part in in-person and phone interviews in which they were asked to reflect on their participation in the conference specifically and provide their impressions of the Dozier Project more generally from the perspective of community outreach.⁸ The range of views expressed in these follow-up interviews address the future for Dozier with respect to memorialization and the pursuit of justice. Additionally, the interviews can be understood to underscore how talking to the living can challenge ways of knowing in areas of decision making, for example, making policy decisions about archaeology and how to interpret and process human remains. From my perspective, they broaden any critiques and interpretations of processes of memorialization in the present for those tasked with developing policies and plans for the future.

For example, Jose Baraybar (interviewed by Melissa Sedlacik, 2015), the director of the Peruvian Forensic Anthropology Team (an invited conference panelist and recognized forensic expert who runs a field school that trains students in areas of justice, development, memory, and human rights at a community level), said that he considered himself to be an outsider to the project. As an outsider, he is interested in whether or not and how the

project and history revealed in its results can be memorialized. He believes that if attempts are pursued to memorialize results derived from the project, then questions—such as, memorialized for what, and for whom, and with whose permission?—must be addressed. He pointed out that the conference tried to be apolitical but that everything, nevertheless, is political and that this political perspective should be fully pursued.

Dixie Peters (interviewed by Melissa Sedlacik 2015), of the University of Texas Health Sciences Center (UNTHSC) and who is involved with the lab conducting DNA testing on the skeletal remains, stated that the candlelight ceremony at the end of the conference was very touching. She also indicated that hurt and anger were key themes that had been expressed by attendees at the conference. This seemed to be the case, especially among family members, because of the lack of resolution to the case.

Another conference participant, Peggy Maisel (telephone interview with Melissa Sedlacik, September 3, 2015), a law professor at Boston University who has a background in truth and reconciliation work organized at the community level, said that she appreciated being asked to provide a legal perspective to the conference. She said that a major theme that emerged at the conference was centered on race and criminal justice. Issues of race and criminal justice at Dozier, according to Maisel, can and should connect to current happenings in Florida.

Some of the conference panel participants were interviewed and tape recorded. A few extended quotes from those interviews are offered here to expand the discussion to this point. They provide suggestions on the role of research as an act of community engagement, and they offer some ideas for the future with respect to memorialization and justice:

Everyone has always known what was going on in Dozier was real and horrible, but now we're applying real fact finding, in terms of science and academic understanding, and interviewing people who were there, and really, really connecting the dots. That knowledge translates into an understanding that influences policy. Hopefully, one of the ways that Florida breaks through its horrendous past is that it sits down and pays attention to what happened and comes up with a better system, comes up with better training, comes up with better funding... fully commits to doing right by children, and that would be the ultimate way of honoring the victims of Dozier is to make sure we don't allow something like that to ever happen again. (Victoria Chachere, communication specialist and conference panel participant, interviewed by Melissa Sedlacik 2015)

For what purpose should the individual survivors of a moral catastrophe remember? And to what end is the scholar's project of building a memorial or helping to even think about one? And there are many outcomes or end products. Now one is, let's build a public record against denial, because denial is like a duel murder of the victims. The perpetrators killed them and those who stood by as bystanders for that evil to happen simply decided that they are not worth remembering. That is a double murder of the victims. And while the victims are dead, it is the living who should ethically stand in defense of the memory of them ... I think, in terms of any final thoughts that I have, my thoughts and my suggestions would be that the scholar has to try to build a public memory and building the public memory also helps to build a public record. It is okay to take the side of the victims, because this is a completely different subject matter. This is an ethical perspective subject matter. This is a moral issue subject matter, and

therefore the scholar should stand on the side of what is just, of what is fair, what is moral and what is ethical in defense of victims who can no longer speak for themselves. And then also make his or her scholarship a signpost for future generations that might be tempted to act immorally. (Edward Kissi, an historian and conference panel participant, interviewed by Melissa Sedlaczek 2015)

The conference enabled a wide range of people (i.e., academics, civic leaders, community organizers, legal professionals, clergy, forensic scientists, journalists, and families of victims, as well as men with firsthand experiences of being housed at Dozier) to come together on one day and in one place. The renderings and discussions of these firsthand experiences serve to complicate and inform dialogs about the future. They also support, in my view, the case for utilizing the framework of the uncanny to organize the range of processes, feelings, and knowledge about the past and the future, which is triggered by proximity to trauma.

One of the key goals of introducing issues of civil rights, memorialization, and justice into this discussion has involved connecting the past to the present. The strategy to accomplish this goal is through understanding the history and heritage of people, communities, and institutions directly associated with Dozier, including reflexively considering the impact made by the inquiry and findings of the USF research team. For me, this process represents not so much an act of closure as an opening for a larger conversation concerning the history and heritage of slavery and segregation in the United States and struggles of all Americans for civil rights.

For example on October 21, 2013, I interviewed Richard Washington,* pastor of an African Methodist Episcopal Church in Marianna, Florida. Born in 1953, he has played an active role in recent events surrounding the Dozier School for Boys, including advocating for the exhumation of bodies at Boot Hill Cemetery. He said that several of the members of his church worked at Dozier as house parents and other jobs but that most members did not want to talk directly about their connection to Dozier. He points out that this was probably because they were scared of losing their jobs. Pastor Richard indicated that the view of the church members varies “in terms of a living situation, a job situation, as well as a punishment situation.” However, one of the main questions asked by members of his congregation was “Why is this investigation happening now after all these years?” He also told me the following:

Yeah there was a lot of—there was a lot of conversation—some of our members were asking, why now? After all these years, why ... And I tried to explain to them that during that time a hundred years ago, uh we're talking about, um, when racial discrimination was at one of its highest, you know, moments of when, uh, the kids were signed over to the state, they became wards of the state ... And they wanna know how to get closure, uh, to the point where—I wanna know where they're buried, how they died, so I can take them back and give them a decent burial in our family plot. And so that's how I have been trying to explain to, to people in that they just want closure in their family history as to what happened to so and so ...

I would like that there be closure for all the families. For all of the residents that died, I would like for them to all be identified; and markers placed with their

name on it, and the year that they were born and the year they died. Not necessarily how they died, but just to be identified. (interview with author, October 21, 2013)

Pastor Washington's understanding of his experience and that of his congregation demonstrates how drawing upon or engaging the uncanny as a framework can help tie together multiple levels and types of information associated with locating, exhuming, and identifying human remains associated with burial sites, such as found at Boot Hill Cemetery. The concept of the uncanny demands that we think about next steps as dynamic not fixed. This is so because these next steps must be negotiated in relation to living communities. Because these steps are seen to be open, not closed, there are many stories yet to be told or retold. These steps are also understood to be specific, not generic, because every experience is different and solutions to problems that have been created need to reflect the nuances and complexity of multiple and shared experiences. The concept of the uncanny is also highly compatible with the idea of interconnection in the whole of human experience. We are impacted collectively, either directly or indirectly, and in benign and complex ways, in countless areas of enterprise. This appears to me to be especially true and significant at sites of human trauma.

Conclusion

The uncanny is an effective concept for analyzing dynamic processes associated with death, dying, fear of the unknown, or disruptions to the familiar (see Gelder and Jacobs 1998; Greenop 2008; Leys 2000; Masschelein 2011). It is used here to underscore ways in which exhuming, identifying, and returning human remains to families and communities—in public and private ways and in public or private spaces—connect the past to the present beyond a fixed and materially oriented perspective. Employing the uncanny—whether it be for finding mass graves in Spain following from its Civil War period (1936–1939), rediscovering a burial site and human remains during a public construction project, as in the case of the African Burial Ground, or exhuming bodies at Boot Hill Cemetery at the former Dozier School for Boys in Marianna, Florida, USA—demands critical attention be paid to expectations and intentions with respect to the living. This discussion is aimed at creating a space for thinking about the uncanny with reference to the 1914 fire and the subsequent burial and recovery of the bodies of its victims and others. It interprets the fire and subsequent related events as dynamic, as disruptive, and as having a potentially ongoing and active link between the past, present, and future. None of this can be understood in universal terms, that is, as having the same meaning and being perceived in the same way for every group, family, or community.

This perspective creates a challenge, calling for more nuanced ways of thinking about and addressing tensions and memories that surface in the

context of exhumations and proximity to death. It implies working across multiple communities, and even within specific groups with differing perspectives, concerning what to do next in the present with respect to things, bodies, policies, emotions, and acts of honoring and memorializing. It requires seeking out and including underrepresented groups, people, and stories in the process (e.g., the history of segregation in the United States, including stories and experiences such as those of black men who were sent to Dozier as boys). It means extensively talking with people.

The narratives presented throughout this discussion, such as that of Pastor Richard Washington, as well as archival research and other findings, including the work of the USF research team, together help to illuminate advantages of utilizing the uncanny as a framework of knowing. These narratives help to address tensions that surface—at the intersection between the past and present, at a site of trauma, and as a result of their concern with and proximity to death, burial, and exhumation. The implications of the approach taken here represent not an act of closure but an opening for participating in ever larger and more critical conversations about the present that concern what to do next for the living, for the dead, and for our future. It seems to me that there is a collective social responsibility to confront the totality of the nature of human history and experience in all its complexity.

Notes

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1. A University of South Florida (USF) team of anthropologists, led by Erin H. Kimmerle (Project Principal Investigator), in collaboration with colleagues Antoinette Jackson and E. Christian Wells, conducted research at the former Arthur G. Dozier School for Boys—a reform school in Marianna, Florida. The school is charged with abusing boys in its care almost from its inception in the 1900s until its closure in 2011. Dozier is also the site of the historic *Boot Hill Cemetery*, where many missing and unaccounted for boys are buried in unmarked graves. Beginning in January 2012, the USF team initiated fieldwork to complete a survey of Boot Hill Cemetery and document the history of the burial ground site and variables surrounding the deaths of its occupants, and to establish the number, location, and identity of children who died in State Custody and were buried on the school grounds (Kimmerle

et al. 2012). Funding for the Dozier project was provided in part by the Florida Legislature; the USF Office of the Provost; and the National Institute of Justice, Award No. DN-BX-K002. However, opinions, findings, analyses, and conclusions expressed in this publication are those of the author and do not necessarily reflect those of project funders.

2. USF research findings show a total of 51 individuals buried in 55 graves. Three of these individuals were victims in the 1914 fire of dormitory that burned down. USF believes that the dorm fire likely killed 10 people but remains of the other fire victims have not been located at this time. The discrepancy between 51 individuals and 55 graves is that the fire victims were commingled and spread throughout seven of the graves. Therefore, excluding those with burned fragments and debris, there are 48 graves (Kimmerle et al. 2016).

3. To date (as of January 2016), 7 positive and 14 presumptive identifications have been made. Among the 7 positive identifications, 4 have been repatriated to families and buried in family cemeteries. A total of 51 individuals buried in 55 graves, the remains of which were brought to the Forensic Anthropology Laboratory at the University of South Florida for analysis, have been found (Kimmerle et al. 2016). This analysis is ongoing. Family Reference Samples (FRS) for DNA testing is being collected by the Hillsborough County Sheriff's Office in Tampa. All samples for DNA testing are sent to the University of North Texas Health Sciences Center (UNTHSC) for analysis. The non-genetic information is housed in the NamUs database. The DNA profiles are maintained in UNTHSC's local Combined DNA Index System (CODIS) database.

4. Michael Blakey posited "memorialization" of the dead as an essential language of humans and stated that burying the dead is the first human symbolic behavior, exclusive to humans, and a testament to the humanity of the living. Blakey is a physical anthropologist and founding director of the African Burial Ground Project. He is currently the National Endowment for the Humanities Professor at the College of William and Mary, Department of Anthropology, and Director of the Institute for Historical Biology.

5. In the "Ethnohistorical Study of the New York African Burial Ground National Monument," Dana-Ain Davis and Leith Mullins (2013:iv) state: "Typically, persons associated with a National Park site include former and current residents or neighbors of a particular geographic area. However, this site is unusual not only with respect to the descendant community itself but also because of the constellation of scientists, activists, preservation and design experts, politicians, and other members of the public that became intimately involved with the development and evolution of the African Burial Ground (ABG) site." They are all "stakeholders."

6. I have interviewed or talked to approximately 15 men who were sent to Dozier as boys. Transcription of interviews of men who agreed to be audio taped or video recorded were done by the USF Oral History Program, Florida Studies Center. One outcome of the Boot Hill Burial Ground Project is the documentation of findings including cemetery findings and interviews in a USF Digital Library Collection. This collection adds to the public record and informs public policy making targeted at addressing what is next for families and for the State of Florida in terms of responsibility and memorialization.

7. Throughout this article, I use "*" to indicate the use of an alias in place of an interviewee's real name. This was done to protect the privacy of those interviewed and in recognition of emotional sensitivity and vulnerability of participants with respect to information shared.

8. USF graduate student, Melissa Sedlacik, conducted 15 semiformal interviews between May 2015 and September 2015 with people who participated in the November 18, 2014 conference as organizers, panelists, or discussants. She either met with participants directly or conversed with them over the phone. Some of the interviews were audio taped. Interviewees were first given the opportunity to share general or overall observations about the conference and the Dozier Project more generally. They were then asked a series of topical questions ranging from their roles in the

symposium to moments that they considered particularly significant. Excerpts from some of these interviews appear in this discussion.

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